

Starlight's Shoreline

A clacking of stilettos against the sidewalk cuts through the conversations along its way. The sound traces back to a sleek, feminine silhouette, completed by wavy locks of copper which stop at her thighs. A plum-colored long coat shrouds her body from the sunlight, and a black panama hat hides her eyes from the crowds. Ozone clings to her clothing, to which the olfaction of each stranger reacts.

A bejeweled tourist whispers to their husband, "Isn't that the Alchemist?"

People old and young, nearby and from the adjacent blocks begin to accumulate within the lady's vicinity. The sound of cameras clicking and flashing shifts from Prometheus's statue to fill her ears. From her left peripheral, she can see a little girl sitting atop her father's shoulders, waving at her. She bares all 32 at the girl, beaming like a quokka. From her right, a news journalist waves a microphone at her mouth, an inch from smacking her lips with it.

"Ms. Kadim, your recent endowments of climate-controlled repositories, in the name of codicology and fragmentology—"

Her breath hardens when she curtails the journalist's statements with her own. "Your mercy, friend, but I have a meeting to attend."

She settles back into a stride as her breath softens, pressing on through Rockefeller Center and slipping into the joints of the alleyways. Her silhouette sautés and fouettés through a route of fire escapes and rooftops without pausing to breathe, passing St. Patrick's Cathedral, the MoMA, and eventually stopping at Billionaires' Row.

Ever since the late nineteenth century, I've dreamt of trying my hand in modern architecture...

Down the street, she can see the Hylic Partners' second headquarters, watching over the insomniac city. Thousands of undead process in and out of the skyscraper, until one glances at her and freezes in place, trumpeting, "It's the boss!"

The horde erupts into silence, standing at attention to the Alchemist. Two concierges, Rae and Les, jolt from their desk in tandem with everyone else.

"Wait, why are we standing?" Les asks, adjusting her spectacles.

"I don't know, you're the one that can see!" Rae sneers. "I think someone shouted something about the boss."

"Really?! Let me see!"

Rae gives a thumbs up, hoisting Les over her shoulders. “If you fall on my face again, I’ll make sure Daniel never feels your teeth.”

“...Hold up, there’s like half of New York City behind her!”

Paparazzi and the public aggregate into a second horde that buries the gravel and concrete, having caught up from before. Security guards sprint from their stations to form a phalanx, cutting the crowd off from the Alchemist.

That pillar of creation is what years of Conceptual and Schematic Design have led up to; these sycophants are what decades of building rapport molded; the Alchemist is what centuries of living have likened me to.

She tips her hat to the Earth, the brim’s shadow shrouding her visage as she continues forward. The felsenmeer of her employees splits apart as she nears the entrance, a toothy pattern carved into the sea of rocks.

How embarrassing.

The Alchemist’s red carpet extends through the entrance, past the front desk, and to the elevator, which the eight people inside vacate. She bows to each person on her way in whilst she grips her hat, her fingers blanching.

“MS. KADIM!” A final reporter shouts, two steps ahead of the paparazzi and the public. The voice matches the frequency of one buried in the strata of her Headspace, causing the borders of her eyes to expand. Her body stops one step from the elevator, tracing a semicircle to pay her regard.

“Your executives say you came to America to expand your company, though I believe there to be a grander reason that sets with the sun!”

The other half of the circle is drawn, and a second step carries the Alchemist into the elevator. Before the cab doors close, however, her face avulses from the headwear hiding it, shining two rubies into the stone sea.

“The sun is setting every day, Mr. De Souza. There can’t be only one answer,” she remarks.

He barks back, “You can’t run from the sun forever, Ms. Kadim!”

Not another word reaches her as the doors slide shut. She hugs her hat to her bosom like a stuffed animal while panting like a live one.

“At least he didn’t call me by my first name,” she mutters. “Gareth, that rascal. Does he think judgment day is upon us alr—”

A mushroom cloud ignites the horizon overhead, its brilliance mocking her erotesis.
She falls flat on her butt as she backs up, but continues to scoot towards the corner of the cab. Her hands try to muffle her cries, but she can't find her mouth. *Where is my mouth? I can't feel my mouth. I can't feel my face. Where is my face?*

[TBC]